MARYLAND

The Old Line State



The Chesapeake Bay has never been a quiet place. Stretching nearly 200 miles from the Susquehanna River south to the Virginia capes, it is the largest estuary in the United States—a vast mixing of fresh and saltwater that has produced one of the most remarkable natural larders the continent has ever offered. At the center of that larder sits Callinectes sapidus, the blue crab, whose Latin name means "beautiful swimmer, savory."

Long before European settlers arrived, the Algonquin-speaking peoples of the Chesapeake—among them the Piscataway, on the western shores of present-day Maryland—harvested blue crabs seasonally, steaming and boiling them over open fires. They understood what generations of Marylanders would later confirm: a Chesapeake blue crab caught at the height of summer needs almost nothing to become extraordinary.

When English settlers founded St. Mary's City in 1634, they learned from their Piscataway neighbors how to read the water and what it held. Crabs were so plentiful in the early colonial period that they were dismissed as poor man's food. That reputation didn't last.

By the 19th century, the watermen of the Chesapeake had built a way of life around the bay's harvest. Working out of Crisfield—a small Eastern Shore port that would crown itself the Crab Capital of the World—these men, many the sons and grandsons of English settlers and freed Black Marylanders, worked deadrise workboats: tonging oysters in winter, crabbing through the summer heat. Their wives and daughters worked the crab picking houses along the Crisfield waterfront, hands flying through mountains of steamed crabs to extract the sweet lump meat shipped up and down the Eastern Seaboard.

It was in these working communities that steaming crabs with seasoning took hold. Old Bay, that iconic blend of celery salt, paprika, and warm spices, was created in Baltimore in 1939 by Gustav Brunn, a German immigrant who fled Nazi Germany with his spice-grinding expertise in tow. The blend found its home on the Chesapeake, coating layers of live crabs stacked over steaming pots of vinegar and beer—a method that locks the seasoning into the shell and perfumes the meat with something impossible to replicate any other way.

What followed was a ritual as Maryland as the flag itself. Newspaper spread across a picnic table. A wooden mallet in hand. Cold beer nearby. Spiced steam rising before the first crab is even cracked. This isn't merely a meal—it's a summertime ceremony, passed down along every river, dock, and backyard in the state.

Steam a bushel of Maryland blue crabs, and you're part of something that stretches back centuries and across cultures—from Piscataway fires on the Western Shore, to the docks of Crisfield, to your own table tonight. The cracking and picking is part of the pleasure, and the reward—sweet, tender, Old Bay-kissed crabmeat—is worth every moment. Fire up the pot. Spread the paper. This is Maryland at its finest.

STEAMED CRABS

Elbow-to-elbow at a newspaper-covered table, cracking Old Bay-dusted crabs with the people you love—Maryland's finest afternoon.

Yield: 2–4 servings

INGREDIENTS

- 12 live blue crabs, males (Jimmies) preferred
- 1 cup white vinegar
- 1 cup beer or water
- ¼ cup salt
- ½ cup Old Bay seasoning, plus more to serve
- ½ cup melted butter (optional, to serve)
- ½ cup vinegar (optional, to serve)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Prepare the steaming pot*: Use a large stockpot with a steaming rack. Add vinegar, beer (or water), and salt to the bottom (about 2 inches deep). Set the rack in the pot and make sure the liquid stays below it; pour off any extra.
2. *Layer the crabs*: Keep crabs cold and discard any dead crabs before cooking. Using tongs, place a layer of live crabs on the steaming rack. Generously sprinkle Old Bay seasoning. Repeat layers until all crabs are in the pot.
3. *Steam the crabs*: Cover tightly and steam over medium-high heat for 25–30 minutes, until the crabs turn bright orange-red. (For a full bushel, steam in batches.)
4. *Serve hot*: Sprinkle extra Old Bay on top and serve with melted butter, or vinegar for dipping.

